Although done to serve national interests, this practice reinforced the interpretation of Pakistan as an Islamic vanguard responsible for protecting Muslims beyond its borders. The state also promoted a vehemently anti-Hindu discourse, thus contributing to the conception that fighting against India was the most legitimate jihad.[7] One result was to blur the communal and universal interpretations of Islam in Pakistan, which helps to explain two important characteristics of Pakistani jihadism: first, most jihadi groups historically prioritized pan-Islamist campaigns abroad for which they enjoyed state sanction; and second, this pan-Islamism at times has been fused with a vicious anti-Hinduism. Finally, by promoting Islam as a means to bind the country together internally and project power externally, Pakistan's rulers also blurred the lines between Islamist activism at home and abroad. The major jihadi outfits that flourished during the past several decades were tied to religious parties that reaped domestic support for various reasons, enabling the construction of madaris as well as charitable institutions. This exacerbated sectarian competition among them as well as their militant offshoots for official support, but bolstered the collective belief that Pakistan's creation would not be fully complete until it was an Islamic state. It also contributed to their ability to penetrate pockets of Pakistani society through social outreach in order to advance their Islamist agenda.

Lashkar is a product of this environment. The group was always motivated by a pan-Islamist rationale for jihad, but has fixated overwhelmingly on India since the mid-1990s.[8] This preoccupation was compounded by the fact that its base of supporters was in Punjab province and Pakistan-administered Kashmir, where backing for the Kashmir cause is strongest. Lashkar was not immune to the increasing hybridization that has characterized many outfits in recent years, but the leadership's focus on India continues to rival al-Qaeda's historical preoccupation with America. It is also arguably more dedicated to dawa than any other Pakistani jihadi outfit. Indeed, the group pursues different rationales for activism—one violently and one non-violently—in different theaters with near equal vigor. The seeds of this dual focus were sown at the organization's founding, when Saeed's preaching organization merged with Lakhvi's military outfit. Although the group dedicated the majority of its resources to jihad during its earliest years, state support enabled it to actualize its commitment to